

ESSENTIAL

Standard Visitor Visa Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - process, genuine visitor test, permitted activities, and FAQs

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

What the Standard Visitor visa is - and isn't

The Standard Visitor visa is the route most people use to visit the UK for tourism, visiting family or friends, short business activities, or certain medical treatment. It's governed by Appendix V: Visitor of the Immigration Rules. It does not permit taking employment in the UK, and it does not permit enrolling in a full course of study - short recreational courses (up to 30 days) are generally the exception, not general study.

The process end to end

Step	What happens
1. Apply online	Complete the application at gov.uk. You'll get a GWF reference number - keep it.
2. Pay the fee	Fees are tiered by visa length (6 months, 2, 5, or 10 years); longer visas cost more but each visit is still capped at 6 months, unless you hold a specific longer-stay category.
3. Prove your identity	Either enrol biometrics at a UK Visa Application Centre (UKVCAS/VFS Global), or use the UK immigration ID Check app if your passport and country are eligible.
4. Submit documents	Upload or present supporting evidence - see the Document Checklist.
5. Decision	Most Standard Visitor applications are decided on paper by an Entry Clearance Officer, without an interview. Standard processing is commonly around 3 weeks; priority services (extra fee) can be faster.
6. Get your visa	If approved, you'll typically get a digital immigration status (eVisa) rather than a physical vignette in most current applications - check gov.uk for the current process for your application type.

What counts as a genuine visit

Appendix V asks the ECO to be satisfied you are a genuine visitor, meaning (in summary) that you will leave the UK at the end of your visit, that you won't live in the UK for extended periods through frequent or successive visits, that your visit is consistent with the purpose of the visit route, and that you won't undertake anything beyond the permitted activities. This is the closest UK equivalent to “ties to home country” in other visa systems - strong evidence of your life at home (job, family, property, ongoing study) supports this.

Permitted activities

Standard Visitors can do more than pure tourism, within limits. Broadly permitted:

- Tourism, sightseeing, and visiting family or friends
- General business activities: attending meetings, conferences, negotiating and signing deals/contracts (but not directly working or filling a role in a UK-based business)
- Certain paid engagements, for specific professionals invited by a UK organisation, within strict conditions
- Short recreational courses (up to 30 days)
- Certain medical treatment

Anything resembling employment - being paid by a UK company for work performed in the UK, or taking a role that would otherwise need a work visa - falls outside the visitor route entirely.

Financial requirement

There is no fixed, published minimum bank balance for a Standard Visitor visa. What's required is evidence that you can maintain and accommodate yourself (and any dependants) without working or relying on UK public funds, and that you can cover your return or onward journey. See the Financial Requirements Overview for how to evidence this.

How long you can stay, and multi-entry visas

Whichever visa length you're granted (6 months, 2, 5, or 10 years), each individual visit is still generally limited to 6 months maximum. A 2/5/10-year visa is a multiple-entry visa that lets you make repeated visits over that period - it does not let you stay continuously for years. Frequent, near-continuous visits can themselves raise a "genuine visitor" concern on a later application, even if each individual stay was within the rules.

Frequently asked questions

Can I work on a Standard Visitor visa?

No, other than the narrow list of permitted business activities and specific paid engagements described above - general employment is not allowed.

Do I need travel insurance to apply?

It's not a strict requirement to hold a visa, but the UK has no free public healthcare access for most visitors (beyond emergency care), so insurance is strongly advisable regardless.

What if my passport doesn't support the ID Check app?

You'll be directed to book a biometric appointment at a Visa Application Centre instead - this is still the standard route for many applicants.

What if I'm refused?

See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for Administrative Review eligibility and how to approach reapplying.